

Memorandum

To: Dr. Ernest Gibson, Dr. Derek Ross, Dr. Susan Youngblood
From: Jolisa Brewster
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Subject: Usability (UX) Testing Analysis
Keywords: issues, approaches, usability, user-experience, research, methods

Purpose

This analysis highlights the theories applied in Dr. Susan Youngblood's graduate course, Issues and Approaches for a usability research evaluation. As part of a small team, we conducted a usability evaluation in a technologically mediated space.

Audience and Context

The objective of this research was to identify a client need and conduct a comprehensive user testing evaluation. Our client was the Jule Collins Smith Museum of Art, who had a newly launched front facing collection data base webpage and wanted us to identify specific areas for improvement to enhance the database's overall performance. My role within this team was observer/ co-researcher which contributed to the final report identifying targeted area for improvements and recommendations for the client. The primary target audience for this research usability testing was Auburn University students, faculty, and the public seeking information on art collections.

Theory and Application

Usability research is a primary method used in technical communication, focusing on how people interact with information, tools, and documentation which is driven by a problem or need for understanding (Hayhoe & Brewer, 2020). These insights gained from our usability research was intended to inform decision making, enabling technical communicators to make more effective choices than they would without that knowledge. The team ensured that we understood the knowledge level

and expectations of the end users interacting with the website. Although research is assumed to be objective, it is inherently shaped by perspective (Hayhoe and Brewer, 2020). This understanding guided how we conducted usability testing on the client's website.

Evaluation: Data Collection Methods & Tools

The usability test was conducted through an applied mixed-method research design, which allowed us to better understand the audience's background and challenges experienced. The System Usability Scale (SUS) is widely used to assess usability, as it provides a simple "ten-item scale giving a global view of subjective assessments of usability" (Brooke, n.d., p.1). This approach combined a structured survey questionnaire - the System Usability Scale (SUS) - with Think- Aloud Protocols (TAP) conducted with five participants.

The survey questions collected quantitative data on participants' initial reaction, ease of navigation, content clarity and overall satisfaction. The Think-Aloud-Protocol (TAP) enabled users to verbalize their thoughts while navigating the website, providing rich qualitative insights into their immediate reactions, facial expressions, cognitive processes, and pain points while navigating the website. Additional methods included notetaking and speech recording using voice recording software. The usability testing was conducted in controlled environment at the Jule Museum study room, with participants using their own electronic devices.

Conclusion

In usability research, technical communicators work their way through repeated testing and revisions. Feedback gathered from our usability testing helped us to identify user pain points and frustrations while also identifying key areas and making recommendations to improve usability and accessibility on the Jule Collins Smith Museum website.

References

Brooke, J. (1995). SUS: A 'Quick and Dirty' Usability Scale. In *Usability Evaluation in Industry*. CRC Press.

George F. Hayhoe, P. E. (2020). *A Research Primer for Technical Communication*. Routledge.